

Introduction

Somewhere in the world, it is always time for dinner. That happy fact is one of the joys of travel, as much a part of the vacation experience as visiting a destination's top sights. Rome offers the thrill of walking in the footsteps of the Caesars inside the Roman Forum and gazing heavenward at the Biblical tales that Michelangelo splashed across the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel. Yet the cuisine of the Eternal City is equally unforgettable. After a day of sightseeing, earthy fried artichokes – *carciofi alla giudia* – await in a neighborhood trattoria where the white-shirted waiter balances plates over his head as he weaves between tightly packed

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memory. Anyone who has ever visited Marrakech associates the lemony tang of a Moroccan chicken tagine with the phantasmagorical scene of evening dining on Jemaa el-Fna, the medina's central square. One nibble and it all floods back: the scent of wood smoke, calls to prayer rising from surrounding mosques, the nasal flutes of snake charmers, the deepening color of the sky

tables. There is no better way of finding out what makes a nation tick than through its culinary traditions.

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as it arches from dusky rose to inky blue. Even months later, a single bite can summon up happy memories of an entire vacation.

But food is more than memory's trigger: it also recalls the deep history of a place. Long after people change their language, their dress, and even their religion, they continue cooking like their ancestors. Fresh food markets, many of which are featured in these pages, are tangible links between past and present. Winding mountainside streets and elaborate Spanish Baroque churches make Ecuador's Quito the best-preserved colonial city in the Americas. Yet its market stands brimming with potatoes speak of an era when Andean peasants first domesticated the humble spud, centuries before the conquistadors or even the Incas. Hungry travelers who tuck into a hearty bowl of the Ecuadoran potato stew, *locro de papa*, savor history one bite at a time.

In contrast to the epic sweep of the centuries, family traditions are often inextricably tied to the simple act of dining. A traveler in the right place at the right time might feel like a member of the extended clan. For many families in Rio de Janeiro, Sunday would be incomplete without a swim in the gentle surf and a romp on the sands of Ipanema Beach, immortalized in the bossa nova tune "The Girl from Ipanema." Equally important is the afternoon gathering at an Ipanema restaurant to share a large casserole

Below (left and center) A luxury chocolate shop in Brussels, Belgium; women selling vegetables at a street market in Jaisalmer, Rajasthan, India

